months passed, we lost heart and gradually came to face the fact that we were quite likely to remain childless.

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As I progressed on my dissertation, I went over it with Dawson, who insisted on considering each sentence at length and deciding how it could be made more accurate.

It was a chore for me because I was used to writing quickly and to consider only my own judgment in such matters. However, I wasn't writing for an editor but for a committee of professors, and Professor Dawson knew better than I how to appease them. I therefore consistently followed his suggestions, although I moaned now and then.

The greatest difficulty arose over my use of the constant M. I had introduced it at the appropriate time to indicate how the well-known chronometric equation, which had appeared in a number of papers emerging from Professor Dawson's group, could be corrected and, by use of it, made more nearly a straight-line function.

After a while, Dawson put down his pen and said, "What is M?"

I was surprised. "Why, you know what it is, Dr. Dawson. It's mixing time."

"Why don't you say so?"

Now I was really surprised. "But Dr. Dawson, if I say so now, I kill the suspense." I couldn't believe that I had to explain this.

"Isaac," he said, "I hate to break the news to you, but you're not writing one of your science-fiction stories."

I was horrified. "You mean I have to define M?"

"The instant you first use it."

I did so, though I muttered something about "ruining the whole thing."

It really did spoil my fun and erased any pleasure I could have had in the dissertation. Nor did it really help. Once it was all done and under consideration, one professor was reported to have said, "It reads like a mystery story." And he didn't say it with approval.